

The lush hillsides and forests of Arunachal Pradesh, India, are part of the Indo-Burma biodiversity hotspot. The area contains some 40 per cent of India's animal and plant species.

"Our welfare is intimately tied up with the welfare of wildlife … by saving the lives of wild species, we may be saving our own."

Norman Myers

Protective measures

Conservation agencies agree on targets for every hotspot. They list species that are threatened and make plans to conserve and manage those areas with suitable habitat and viable populations of target plants and animals. Sites are ranked according to how vulnerable and irreplaceable they are.

Myers' two criteria have been criticized by those who say they do not take account of changing land use in regions where less than 70 percent of good habitat has been destroyed. The Amazon rain forest, for example, is